$$|\vec{\tau}_{ext}| = |\vec{\tau}_E| = |\vec{p} \times \vec{E}| \qquad (1.50)$$

Substituting equation (1.50) in equation (1.49), we get

$$W = \int_{\theta'}^{\theta} pE \sin\theta \, d\theta$$
$$W = pE(\cos\theta' - \cos\theta)$$

This work done is equal to the potential energy difference between the angular positions θ and θ'.

$$U(\theta) - U(\theta') = \Delta U = -pE\cos\theta + pE\cos\theta'$$

If the initial angle is $\theta' = 90^\circ$ and is taken as reference point, then $U(\theta') = pE\cos 90^\circ = 0$.

The potential energy stored in the system of dipole kept in the uniform electric field is given by

$$U = -pE\cos\theta = -\vec{p}\cdot\vec{E} \qquad (1.51)$$

In addition to p and E, the potential energy also depends on the orientation θ of the electric dipole with respect to the external electric field.

The potential energy is maximum when the dipole is aligned anti-parallel ($\theta = \pi$) to the external electric field and minimum when the dipole is aligned parallel ($\theta = 0$) to the external electric field.

EXAMPLE 1.16

A water molecule has an electric dipole moment of 6.3×10^{-30} Cm. A sample contains 10^{22} water molecules, with all the dipole moments aligned parallel to the external electric field of magnitude 3×10^5 N C^{-1}. How much work is required to rotate all the water molecules from $\theta = 0^o$ to 90°?

Solution

When the water molecules are aligned in the direction of the electric field, it has minimum potential energy. The work done to rotate the dipole from $\theta = 0^o$ to 90° is equal to the potential energy difference between these two configurations.

$$W = \Delta U = U(90^\circ) - U(0^\circ)$$

From the equation (1.51), we write $U = -pE\cos\theta$, Next we calculate the work done to rotate one water molecule from $\theta = 0^o$ to 90°.

For one water molecule

$$W = -pE\cos 90^\circ + pE\cos 0^\circ = pE$$
$$W = 6.3\times10^{-30}\times3\times10^5 = 18.9\times10^{-25}\,\text{J}$$

For 10^{22} water molecules, the total work done is

$$W_{tot} = 18.9\times10^{-25}\times10^{22} = 18.9\times10^{-3}\,\text{J}$$

1.6 GAUSS LAW AND ITS APPLICATIONS

1.6.1 Electric Flux

The number of electric field lines crossing a given area kept normal to the electric field lines is called electric flux. It is usually denoted by the Greek letter Φ_E and its unit is N m^2 C^{-1}. Electric flux is a scalar quantity and it can be positive or negative. For a simpler understanding of electric flux, the following Figure 1.30 is useful.

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